# PIA2050 Comparative Politics and Societies — Week 2 Summary: Research Programs/Traditions

## 1. Recap and Agenda (Slide 2)

**Keywords:** comparative politics, domestic politics, description, explanation, research programs, theory

### 1.1 What Comparative Politics Is

**Keywords:** subfield, political actors, political institutions, political processes

- Comparative Politics is a discipline that focuses on the internal or domestic politics of any country, entailing the study of political actors, political institutions, and political processes — one of Political Science's main subfields.
- Comparativists use evidence for two purposes (memorise):
    - **Description:** describing differences and similarities across political systems.
    - **Explanation:** developing/testing theories on the causes or consequences of outcomes, or their variation across time and space.
- *Example:* noting that some countries hold competitive elections = description; asking *why* some are democratic and others authoritarian = explanation.

### 1.2 Today's Agenda

**Keywords:** history of the field, traditions of inquiry, theory development

- History of the field (Section 2) → its main research programs / "traditions of inquiry" (Sections 4–7) → principles for explaining phenomena through "theories" (Sections 8–9).

## 2. The Field's Past (Slide 3)

**Keywords:** legal structures, 1950s shift, causal focus, behavioral revolution, Cold War

### 2.1 From Legalism to Explanation

**Keywords:** formal-legal, descriptive, informal politics, methodological sophistication

- Early C.P.: **descriptive comparison of countries' domestic legal structures**.
- 1950s: a **more explanatory (causal), less formal/legalistic** focus, because **a nation's laws do NOT tell anywhere close to the complete story** of how its politics works; plus greater **theoretical/methodological sophistication**.
- *Example:* a constitution guarantees free elections, but real politics runs on patronage or intimidation — the legal text misses it.

### 2.2 Why the Switch (memorise)

**Keywords:** behavioral revolution, game theory, statistics, technology, Cold War, Hitler, WW2

- **(i) The behavioral revolution** in the social sciences — coincided with interest in **real/informal politics**, popularity of **game theory** and **statistical methods**; **technology** made statistics accessible.
- **(ii) Geopolitical context** — the **American determination to win the Cold War** and to understand **Hitler's rise / World War 2**.

## 3. The Field Today (Slides 4–5)

**Keywords:** Lichbach & Zuckerman, ambitious scope, intellectual visions, big questions

### 3.1 Three Characteristics (Slide 4)

**Keywords:** scope of inquiry, general questions, social thought

- Lichbach & Zuckerman 1997 (from Week 1):
  - **Ambitious scope:** no political phenomenon is foreign to it, no level of analysis irrelevant, no time period beyond its reach.
  - **Ambitious intellectual visions:** cases are approached with general questions in mind, not for their own sake.
  - **Concern for the "big questions"** of social thought.
- One-liner: **cases are studied for what they reveal about general questions.**

### 3.2 The Big Questions (Slide 5, from the course outline)

**Keywords:** state-building, democracy, institutions, participation, conflict, development

- Why do **state-/nation-building** processes fail? Why are some countries **democratic** and others **authoritarian**?
- How do **institutions** develop, and how do form of government, electoral system and federalism affect stability and prosperity? Can outcomes be **"engineered"**?
- What drives **participation** and **protest**? What explains the intensity of **inter-group conflict**? How does politics affect **economic development**?

## 4. Three Research Programs (Slide 6)

**Keywords:** rationalist, structuralist, culturalist, schools of thought, synthesis

- Lichbach & Zuckerman 1997 identify three main approaches / traditions / "research programs" (memorise): Rationalist, Structuralist, Culturalist.
- Research programs are not exactly "theories" but "schools of thought" sharing basic assumptions, tools/strategies of inquiry, and perspectives on behaviour/political reality.

    - *Example:* "democracy emerges when the middle class grows" is a theory; the structuralist program is the wider view that material conditions drive political change.

- **Great variation** within each tradition; **many attempts to synthesise** them for better explanations of particular cases.
- → Treat them as **lenses**, not rival teams.

## 5. Structuralists (Slides 7–9)

**Keywords:** Marx, historical materialism, macro-level processes, modernity, non-voluntaristic

### 5.1 Roots: Historical Materialism (Slide 7)

**Keywords:** Karl Marx, relations of production, class structure, technology

- Deeply influenced by Karl Marx, above all historical materialism.
- Historical materialism assumes that the evolution of a country's social and political organisation — indeed the progression of history as a whole — is driven by changes in material conditions like relations of production, class structure, and available technologies.
- *Example:* the shift from feudal agriculture to industrial capitalism created new classes (bourgeoisie, workers), and political institutions changed to reflect the new class balance.

### 5.2 Core Assumptions (Slide 8)

**Keywords:** macro processes, large-scale features of modernity, interests, identities

- Structuralists assume that social life and individual actions are shaped by macro-level processes.
- Processes shaping interests/identities = the **"large-scale features of modernity"** (memorise the five): **capitalist development, diffusion of markets, technological change, state formation, nation-building**.

### 5.3 Non-Voluntarism (Slide 8)

**Keywords:** impersonal forces, sequencing, collectivities, classes

- A non-voluntaristic approach: social outcomes result from impersonal, structural forces and the sequencing of these processes, not from individual decisions.
- Individual behaviour depends on one's **relation to structural forces** and to the **collectivities/classes** involved.
- *Example:* a worker's vote is explained by class position, not personal deliberation.

### 5.4 In a Nutshell (Slide 9)

**Keywords:** material determinism, constraints, agency, inevitability

- **Nutshell:** social and political organisation is **determined by material conditions** (production, class/inequality, technology); **political systems change through structural change**.
- **Strength:** history is made in **circumstances beyond any participant's control** — structures impose crucial **constraints**.
- **Weakness: underestimates individual agency**; **overstates "inevitability"**.

## 6. Culturalists (Slides 10–12)

**Keywords:** culture, system of meaning, five functions, logic of appropriateness, socialisation

### 6.1 Defining Culture (Slide 10)

**Keywords:** system of meaning, identities, shared understanding

- Culture is a system of meaning that people use to manage their daily worlds; it can be the basis of social and political identities that affect how people think and act.
- Sharing a culture ≠ agreeing on specifics — only **a similar understanding of how the world works**.

### 6.2 Five Functions of Culture (Slides 10–11, memorise)

**Keywords:** context, identity, boundaries, interpretation, mobilisation

- **(1) Frames the context of politics:** which symbolic/material objects are **worth fighting over**; the **rules/norms** of politics; beliefs about **community, authority, conflict**.
- **(2) Links individual and collective identities:** "identification" makes some actions reasonable and **removes alternatives** plausible on other grounds (e.g. **self-interest**).
    - *Example:* a devout believer refuses a profitable deal seen as violating the community's norms.
- **(3) Defines group boundaries:** sets **expectations of behaviour/association** within and between groups.
- **(4) Interprets others' actions and motives:** motives are **context-dependent** — what one wants depends on **what one's society values**.
- **(5) Resources for organisation and mobilisation: "repertoires" of action are a "learned cultural creation"**.
    - *Example:* petitions, sit-ins or candlelight vigils are scripts a society learns and reuses.
- Mnemonic: **Context – Identity – Boundaries – Interpretation – Mobilisation.**

### 6.3 Logic of Appropriateness (Slide 11)

**Keywords:** fit in, situational rules, socialisation

- Logic of (social) appropriateness: people are motivated primarily by the desire to "fit in", acting in accordance with rules that define what is appropriate for a given person in a given situation, acquired through **(cultural) socialisation**.
- *Example:* standing for the national anthem — not a payoff calculation, just "what one does".
- → Contrast: culturalists ask *what is appropriate?*; rationalists ask *what pays?*

### 6.4 In a Nutshell (Slide 12)

**Keywords:** cultural determinism, intentionality, inevitability, no mechanism for change

- **Nutshell:** social and political organisation is **determined by culture** (rules/norms of politics, beliefs about authority and institutions); **political systems change through cultural change**.
- **Strength:** the logic of appropriateness **accounts for a great deal of behaviour**.
- **Weakness: understates intentionality**; **overstates inevitability**; **no mechanism for change**.

## 7. Rationalists (Slides 13–19)

**Keywords:** methodological individualism, instrumental rationality, equilibrium, collective action, micro-foundations

### 7.1 The Rationalist Mission (Slide 13)

**Keywords:** aggregation, interactions, uncertainty, game theory, micro-foundations, universal laws

- **(i)** Show how **rational individual action generates collective action** — sometimes with **irrational consequences**.
- **(ii)** Stress **aggregation** and **interactions** — actions taken in response to expectations about the behaviour of others.
- **(iii)** Choices occur under **uncertainty**; people differ in **assessing** and **tolerating risk**; game theory models interactions.
- **(iv)** Explain **statistical correlations** with a story identifying the **causal mechanism**: micro-foundations.
    - *Example:* a wealth–democracy correlation gains micro-foundations by showing *why* individuals in richer societies would choose democracy.
- **(v)** Uncover **"laws" valid regardless of time and space**.

### 7.2 Methodological Individualism (Slide 14)

**Keywords:** individuals under constraints, rules, aggregation

- Methodological individualism: all social phenomena can and should be explained in terms of the actions of individuals operating under constraints — on knowledge,

capabilities, resources and behaviour, imposed by **rules structuring social interaction**.

- **Collective action = aggregation of individual decisions**; focus on how we get **from individual choice to social outcomes**.

## 7.3 Instrumental Rationality (Slide 14)

**Keywords:** means not ends, beliefs, non-rational action

- Instrumental rationality: rationality is not about goals or preferences but about the means by which individuals pursue them, and how they process beliefs — **not limited to wealth or naked self-interest**.
- **Non-rational action:** (i) **impulsive/visceral**; or (ii) taken **without regard for consequences** for **deeper psychological reasons**.
- One-liner: **rationality judges the means, not the ends.**

## 7.4 Replies to "Lack of Realism" (Slide 15)

**Keywords:** Friedman, as-if, high stakes, trial and error, natural selection

- **"As if" (Milton Friedman):** people needn't actually calculate expected utility; what matters is that they **act AS IF they do**.
- **Limited scope:** rational choice explains only behaviour where **stakes are high and information available**.
- **Convergence: trial and error** brings expectations/outcomes into line in high-stakes situations; or **natural selection weeds out** irrational actors.
    - *Example:* firms that keep mispricing go bankrupt; politicians who misread voters lose office.

## 7.5 Equilibrium (Slide 16)

**Keywords:** stable outcomes, Nash equilibrium, prisoner's dilemma

- Aim: explain how interaction **produces stable social outcomes**.
- Equilibrium is a situation where nobody has an incentive to change their decisions (memorise).
- Nash equilibrium: in a "game" between two or more players, the situation in which none has an incentive to change his/her actions given the actions of others; e.g. the Prisoner's dilemma.
    - *Example:* two suspects interrogated separately each do better by confessing whatever the other does — both confess, though both silent would be better.
- → Individually rational choices can yield a collectively irrational outcome (Slide 13, point i).

### 7.6 The Logic of Collective Action (Slides 17–18)

**Keywords:** Olson, public goods, non-excludability, free riding, coercion, selective incentives

- Rationalists focus on **obstacles to collective action** and how to overcome them.
- Olson 1965: **individuals with common interests do not always organise to advance them**.
- **Why:** collective action mostly provides public goods — non-excludable goods, where one cannot discriminate between participant and free-rider in distribution; personal interests often **conflict** with group interests.
- **The mechanism** (Slide 18):
    - People value public goods but also have **private interests** — income, time, energy.
    - In a **large group**, no individual affects success or failure; each enjoys the good **irrespective of participation**.
    - So everyone has an incentive to free ride; **if all think this way, nobody acts**.
- *Example:* all residents benefit from cleaner air won by a campaign, marchers or not — so each is tempted to stay home.
- **Solutions** (memorise): **(i) coercion; (ii) selective incentives** (benefits only for participants).
- One-liner: **shared interest ≠ shared action.**

### 7.7 In a Nutshell (Slide 19)

**Keywords:** self-interest, political entrepreneurs, agency, unrealistic assumptions

- **Nutshell:** social and political organisation is **determined by individuals pursuing self-interest**; outcomes hinge on whether and how leaders of organised groups — **"political entrepreneurs" — solve the collective action problem**.
- **Strength:** focus on **individual agency** and **intentionality**.
- **Weakness: incomplete view of motivations**; **unrealistic assumptions** about belief formation and decision-making.

## 8. Critique of Rationalism (Slides 20–21)

**Keywords:** participation puzzle, social incentives, psychological incentives, tautology, falsifiability, paradox of voting

### 8.1 Participation and Three Replies (Slide 20)

**Keywords:** non-participation, social incentives, psychological incentives, tautology

- Rationalists explain **why people do NOT participate** well, **actual participation** poorly. Replies and rebuttals (memorise pairs):
    - **Most people don't participate anyway** → fair, but theory is **still irrelevant to explaining participation**.

    - **"Social incentives"** (prestige, respect, friendship, good time) → fails where **participants are strangers**.
    - **"Psychological incentives"** (feels good) → probably true, but risks tautology: if anything can be called "rational", the theory can never be shown wrong — it is **no longer "falsifiable"**.

- A theory is falsifiable if some possible observation could show it to be false.
- One-liner: **a theory that explains everything explains nothing.**

### 8.2 The Paradox of Voting (Slide 21)

**Keywords:** private costs, decisive vote, civic duty, psychological benefits

- **Paradox:** voting has **private costs** (minor), while the chance of casting the **deciding vote is basically nil** — so "rational" people shouldn't vote.
- **Yet** people vote regularly, in massive numbers, sometimes at **great cost and risk of injury**.
- **Why:** a **sense of civic duty** creating a **moral obligation** (like obeying inconvenient laws), plus **psychological benefits** of doing one's duty or **expressing oneself**.
- **Verdict:** voters aren't "irrational", but **rationalism is not terribly useful** on this important issue.
- → Civic duty resembles the culturalist **logic of appropriateness**.

## 9. An Alternative: Elster (Slides 22–23)

**Keywords:** Jon Elster, beliefs and desires, emotions, interest, passion, reason, normative hierarchy

### 9.1 Keep Individualism, Drop Instrumental Rationality (Slide 22)

**Keywords:** individuals only, beliefs, desires, emotions

- Elster 2007 agrees with rationalists: explanations refer **only to individuals**; collective behaviour is the **aggregate of individual actions**.
- **But** people often don't follow **instrumental rationality**; interpret action through agents' beliefs and desires.
- **Emotions** may **crowd out all other considerations**; even resistible impulses — **visceral cravings** — may block deliberation. Most behaviour is **partly visceral yet sensitive to costs and benefits**.

    - *Example:* anger pushes someone toward a protest, but a likely lethal police response still deters them.

### 9.2 Three Motivations (Slide 22, memorise)

**Keywords:** interest, passion, reason

- **Interest:** pursuit of personal advantage.

- **Passion:** visceral urges.
- **Reason:** desire to promote the public good.

### 9.3 Conflict and Hierarchy of Motives (Slide 23)

**Keywords:** normative hierarchy, justification, appearance of reason

- Motives often **conflict**. Every society has a normative hierarchy of motives: interests and passions **defer to reason**, or to the desire to care about reason — **or appear to**.
- Reason may be **post-hoc justification** for action decided on other grounds; yet the **search for a reasoned justification can change behaviour**.
    - *Example:* a politician seeking re-election (interest) must frame policies as serving the nation (reason), and drops those that can't be publicly defended.

### 9.4 Elster's Explanatory Principle (Slide 23)

**Keywords:** motives independent of action, intentional behaviour

- Explanations should **establish beliefs and motives independently of the action taken or its outcomes** — the fix for Section 8.1's tautology.
- Intentional, goal-oriented behaviour is intelligible only with reference to the agent's underlying motivations/desires and the beliefs that led them to choose one course of action over another to satisfy the goal.
- One-liner: **action = desires + beliefs, each shown on its own evidence.**

## 10. Comparing the Traditions

**Keywords:** determinant, logic of action, strengths, weaknesses, application

- **Determinant / logic of action:**
    - Structuralist — material conditions; behaviour follows **position in structure**.
    - Culturalist — culture; **logic of appropriateness**.
    - Rationalist — self-interest; **instrumental rationality**.
    - Elster — **interest, passion, reason** via beliefs and desires.
- **Shared weakness:** structuralism and culturalism both **overstate inevitability**; rationalism restores **agency** but has **thin motivation** — the gap Elster fills.
- *Example — "Why did country X democratise?":* structuralist: development reshaped class structure; culturalist: democratic norms became appropriate; rationalist: elites found concession cheaper than repression, and opposition leaders solved the collective action problem.
- → Exam technique: name the lens, state its assumption, note its blind spot.

## 11. One-Page Revision Spine

**Keywords:** last-minute recap, history, three traditions, collective action, critique, Elster

1. **C.P.** = domestic politics (actors, institutions, processes); evidence for **description** and **explanation** (Slide 2).
2. **Past:** legal description → 1950s causal focus, since laws don't tell the whole story; driven by the **behavioral revolution** (game theory, statistics, technology) and **geopolitics** (Cold War, Hitler/WW2) (Slide 3).
3. **Today (Lichbach & Zuckerman 1997):** ambitious scope, general intellectual visions, big questions (Slides 4–5).
4. **Research programs:** Rationalist, Structuralist, Culturalist — schools of thought, not theories; often synthesised (Slide 6).
5. **Structuralists:** Marx's historical materialism; five macro processes of modernity; non-voluntaristic; + constraints, – agency/inevitability (Slides 7–9).
6. **Culturalists:** culture = system of meaning; five functions; logic of appropriateness; + explains fitting in, – intentionality, inevitability, no mechanism for change (Slides 10–12).
7. **Rationalists:** individual → collective; interactions, uncertainty, micro-foundations, universal laws; methodological individualism + instrumental rationality (Slides 13–14).
8. **Realism defences:** Friedman's "as if"; high-stakes/high-information only; trial and error or natural selection (Slide 15).
9. **Equilibrium:** nobody has an incentive to change; Nash equilibrium, Prisoner's dilemma (Slide 16).
10. **Collective action (Olson 1965):** non-excludable public goods → free riding; fixes = coercion, selective incentives; outcomes hinge on **political entrepreneurs** (Slides 17–19).
11. **Critique:** explains non-participation, not participation; psychological incentives make it **unfalsifiable**; **paradox of voting** — civic duty and expressive benefits explain turnout (Slides 20–21).
12. **Elster (Elster 2007):** keep individualism, drop instrumental rationality; **interest, passion, reason**; normative hierarchy favours reason; establish motives **independently of action** (Slides 22–23).